EMPOWERING LIVELIHOODS

Two independent studies assess the impact of Odisha's Subhadra scheme on women beneficiaries

What the Subhadra Yojana is

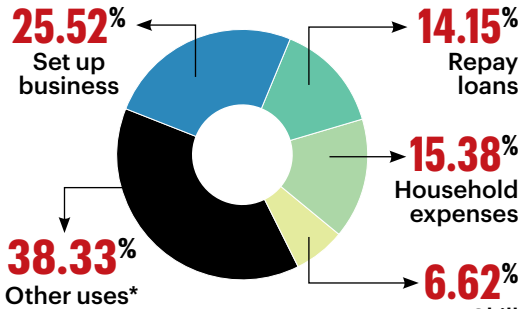
Launched in September 2024, it provides eligible women aged 21-60 with annual financial assistance for five years to support livelihoods and financial autonomy

10.2 MN — No. of eligible beneficiaries

₹20,648 CR — Total outgo since its launch

₹10,000 — Annual payment for five years

How Women Use the Funds



**Assets, savings and other needs*
Source: IIM Sambalpur study

The Impact

What the SBI Research study says

64% take financial decisions independently

31% take decisions jointly with family

59% report greater confidence in managing money

87% say the scheme is "very useful"



ARABINDA MAHAPATRA

The IIM Sambalpur study found those aged 31-40 to be the most entrepreneurial. The younger ones showed a stronger leaning towards investing in skills

Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Sambalpur, one by SBI Research—offer clear evidence on what the scheme is achieving, where it is falling short and what needs to happen next. A ground visit by INDIA TODAY showed just how much the scheme has empowered many women.

On the outskirts of Bhubaneswar, Namita Mishra, 43, had left a private sector job upon maternity a decade ago. Her husband teaches at a private school; money was often tight. After Subhadra, she bought a sewing machine, a wet grinder and started producing homemade spices. "My daughter studies in an English-medium school now. She will have to quit if I don't earn," Namita says. Bangali Barda, featured in the accompanying case study, likewise, had Subhadra fund her dreams.

The two studies broadly endorse this sense of change. The IIM study, Subhadra Samikhya, commissioned by the state women and child development (WCD) department, surveyed 22,000 beneficiaries across Odisha to see where they spend the money, and whether it's enhancing their role within the household and the wider economy. Its findings: Subhadra is beginning to reshape financial behaviour at a primary node.

An overwhelming majority of 64 per cent say they take financial decisions independently. Another 31 per cent make their decisions jointly with family members. Close to six in ten women say they feel more confident managing money after joining the programme; almost 87 per cent describe Subhadra as "very useful", indicating remarkably high public acceptance.

ENTREPRENEURIAL FUEL

Perhaps the most striking finding concerns entrepreneurship. Contrary to the criticism that day-to-day expenses largely consume unconditional cash transfers, the survey found 25.52 per cent of all Subhadra spending goes into setting up businesses, making enterprise-creation a key effect. Dalit beneficiaries are seen to be ahead of the rest here, with nearly one-third directing the money towards income-generating activities.

The IIM report, however, stops well short of presenting a triumphalist picture. For many households, Subhadra is primarily a financial cushion. Over 35 per cent of the money is spent on household needs; another 14 per cent goes towards repaying loans. The study suggests it's not about women being decision-empowered or not. They increasingly control the funds, but their spending decisions are often shaped by family compulsions rather than personal aspirations. The report calls this the "empowerment paradox". Formal financial agency need not translate into genuine economic independence.

The study reveals interesting patterns. Those between 31 and 40 were the most entrepreneurial. The younger ones evinced a stronger leaning towards